Erin M. Sielaff, *Rohit P. Asirvatham*, *Madeline C. Prebil*, and *Mark S. Saudek*.*

JUSTICE SOTOMAYOR delivered the opinion of the Court.

Under what has become known as the *Rooker-Feldman* doctrine, federal district courts lack jurisdiction over "cases brought by state-court losers complaining of injuries caused by state-court judgments rendered before the district court proceedings commenced and inviting district court review and rejection of those judgments." *Exxon Mobil Corp.* v. *Saudi Basic Industries Corp.*, 544 U. S. 280, 284 (2005). This case asks whether this rule bars suit when the state-court judgment at issue is subject to further review in state appellate proceedings. A straightforward application of the logic and reasoning underlying *Rooker-Feldman* leads to one conclusion: It does. Because this suit falls within the narrow doctrine's limits, the Court of Appeals for the Fourth Circuit properly affirmed its dismissal.

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I

A

Petitioner T. M. alleges that she has a medical condition that "'causes changes in [her] mental status upon ingesting any amount of gluten' and can result in 'episodes of psychosis.'" 139 F. 4th 344, 347 (CA4 2025) (alteration in original). In March 2023, T. M. accidentally ingested gluten and was taken to the emergency room at Baltimore Washington Medical Center. After an administrative hearing before a Maryland administrative law judge (ALJ), and over her and her

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*Briefs of *amici curiae* urging reversal were filed for the Constitutional Accountability Center by *Elizabeth B. Wydra* and *Brianne J. Gorod*; for Federal Courts Scholars by *Robert A. Long*; and for the Institute for Justice by *Benjamin A. Field*.

Jack R. Bierig and *Jin Yan* filed a brief of *amici curiae* for the American Medical Association et al. urging affirmance.

Frances L. Diaz filed a brief of *amicus curiae* for Cyrus Sanai.

father's objections, she was involuntarily committed to the facility, where she stayed for about three months. During her stay, T. M.'s treating psychiatrist and the medical center sought, and were granted by a clinic review panel, an order authorizing the facility forcibly to inject T. M. with antipsychotic medication. That order was later affirmed by an ALJ.

These events jumpstarted a flurry of litigation, with T. M. and her parents filing several state and federal lawsuits seeking to have T. M. released from involuntary commitment and to avoid the forced injections. In state court, T. M. filed two petitions for judicial review of the ALJ decisions allowing her involuntary admission and upholding the forced-injection order. She also filed a state habeas petition and a separate civil action, with several emergency motions, seeking release from the medical center. In federal court, T. M. filed a due-process suit seeking damages and an injunction requiring her discharge. T. M.'s father, for his part, filed a state-court action against respondents seeking an order requiring them to recognize T. M.'s purported advance medical directive listing him as T. M.'s healthcare agent if she became incompetent to make decisions.

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In the midst of those lawsuits, T. M. and respondents negotiated a settlement agreement to facilitate T. M.'s discharge, and the state judge presiding over the state habeas petition entered the agreement as a consent order. The consent order provided for T. M.'s immediate release subject to several conditions, including that T. M. would "(1) obtain a new treating psychiatrist and continue to take her hospital-prescribed medications; (2) regularly meet and consult with a third-party provider regarding her treatment and medication; (3) accept a referral to [an outpatient clinic] and follow their recommendations; (4) take all prescribed medications; and (5) dismiss with prejudice all of her [and her parents'] pending actions against [respondents]." App. to Pet. for Cert. 24a. The consent order also required T. M.'s parents to monitor her use of her medications and report if she

stopped taking them. The state court, counsel for T. M., and respondents signed the consent order on June 12, 2023, and respondents discharged T. M.

B

Unfortunately, the consent order did not end the parties' dispute in either state or federal court. Ten days after the state court entered the consent order, T. M. and her parents obtained new counsel and sued respondents in the District Court for the District of Maryland. This lawsuit is now before the Court. The complaint sought a declaration that the consent order violated T. M.'s federal and state due-process rights, a declaration that the order was obtained under duress, and an injunction preventing the order's enforcement.

Meanwhile, back in state court, T. M. appealed the consent order to the Appellate Court of Maryland and raised similar arguments. About four months later, T. M. moved to stay the pending appeal in the Appellate Court of Maryland, contending that a stay was warranted to "prevent inconsistent rulings" because both the state appeal and the pending federal lawsuit were "based on the same facts and events." Motion to Stay in No. 1:23–cv–1684, ECF Doc. 81–1, p. 1. The Appellate Court of Maryland granted the stay, which remains in effect.

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In the federal case, the Maryland District Court dismissed the complaint *sua sponte* for lack of subject matter jurisdiction, holding that T. M.'s claims were barred by the *Rooker-Feldman* doctrine. That doctrine, addressed in detail below, generally holds that federal courts lack jurisdiction over lawsuits brought by parties who received adverse judgments in state courts and then turn to federal courts seeking "review and rejection of" those judgments. *Exxon*, 544 U. S., at 284.[1]

[1] The District Court also granted respondents' motion to dismiss T. M.'s parents' claims on the merits.

The Fourth Circuit affirmed. The panel observed that in *Rooker* v. *Fidelity Trust Co.*, 263 U. S. 413 (1923), this Court held that a Federal District Court lacked jurisdiction to "'declar[e]' that [a] state court's judgment was 'null and void'" under the Federal Constitution because doing so "'would be an exercise of appellate jurisdiction,'" which only the Supreme Court possesses. 139 F. 4th, at 348 (quoting 263 U. S., at 414–415, 416). Because T. M. was asking the District Court here to do precisely that, the Fourth Circuit reasoned that this "case is too much like *Rooker* to justify a different" conclusion and thus required dismissal based on *Rooker-Feldman*. 139 F. 4th, at 346. In so holding, the Fourth Circuit also rejected T. M.'s argument that *Rooker-Feldman* applies only to judgments that are "'final judgment[s] from the highest court of a State in which the decision could be had,'" reasoning that this Court has never imposed such a requirement. 139 F. 4th, at 353–354.

T. M. filed a timely petition for a writ of certiorari seeking review of the Fourth Circuit's conclusion that the *Rooker-Feldman* doctrine can be triggered by a state-court judgment that remains subject to further review in state court. The Sixth Circuit has taken the same position as the Fourth Circuit. See *RLR Invs., LLC* v. *Pigeon Forge*, 4 F. 4th 380, 389–390, 396 (2021). Other Circuits have held that *Rooker-Feldman* applies only if the state-court proceedings have "ended." See, *e. g.*, *Federación de Maestros de P. R.* v. *Junta de Relaciones del Trabajo de P. R.*, 410 F. 3d 17, 24–25 (CA1 2005) (outlining three-part test to determine whether state proceedings have functionally "ended").[2] The Court granted certiorari to resolve the conflict among the Courts of Appeals. 607 U. S. 1079 (2025).

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[2] See also, *e.g.*, *Malhan* v. *Secretary U. S. Dept. of State*, 938 F. 3d 453, 459–460 (CA3 2019); *Nicholson* v. *Shafe*, 558 F. 3d 1266, 1275–1277, and n. 9 (CA11 2009); *Guttman* v. *Khalsa*, 446 F. 3d 1027, 1032, n. 2 (CA10 2006); *Hoblock* v. *Albany Cty. Bd. of Elections*, 422 F. 3d 77, 89 (CA2 2005); *Mothershed* v. *Justices of the Sup. Ct.*, 410 F. 3d 602, 604, n. 1 (CA9 2005).

II

A

"Federal courts are courts of limited jurisdiction and generally can resolve only the cases that Congress grants them power to hear." *Hain Celestial Group, Inc.* v. *Palmquist*, 607 U. S. 421, 424 (2026). As relevant here, Congress in 28 U. S. C. § 1331 granted federal district courts "original jurisdiction of all civil actions" raising federal questions. District courts generally lack "any power to review directly cases from state courts." *Atlantic Coast Line R. Co.* v. *Locomotive Engineers*, 398 U. S. 281, 286 (1970). Instead, this Court is the only federal court with appellate jurisdiction to review state-court judgments, and that jurisdiction extends only to "[f]inal judgments or decrees rendered by the highest court of a State in which a decision could be had." § 1257(a). Thus, "from the beginning we have had in this country two essentially separate legal systems" with "[e]ach system proceed[ing] independently of the other with ultimate review in this Court of the federal questions raised in either system." *Atlantic Coast Line*, 398 U. S., at 286.[3]

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The Court delineated some of the bounds that separate these two systems in *Rooker* and *Feldman*. First, in *Rooker*, the Court held that a Federal District Court lacked jurisdiction to resolve a case that sought "to have a judgment of a circuit court in Indiana, which was affirmed by the Supreme Court of the State, declared null and void" because it violated the Constitution's Due Process, Contracts, and Equal Protection Clauses. 263 U. S., at 414. The Court explained that "entertain[ing] a proceeding to reverse or mod-

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[3] To be sure, "Congress . . . may explicitly empower district courts to oversee certain state-court judgments and has done so, most notably, in authorizing federal habeas review of state prisoners' petitions." *Exxon Mobil Corp.* v. *Saudi Basic Industries Corp.*, 544 U. S. 280, 292, n. 8 (2005) (citing 28 U. S. C. § 2254(a)).

ify [a] judgment for errors of that character" would be "an exercise of appellate jurisdiction." *Id.*, at 415–416. As a result, the suit was "plainly not within the District Court's jurisdiction" because the "jurisdiction possessed by the District Courts is strictly original." *Ibid.* The Court also laid out the path to challenging a state-court judgment: "If the constitutional questions . . . actually arose" in the suit, "it was the province and duty of the state courts to decide them" in the first instance. *Id.*, at 415. "If the decision was wrong, that did not make the judgment void, but merely left it open to reversal or modification in an appropriate and timely appellate proceeding," including through appellate review in this Court. *Ibid.*

Second, in *District of Columbia Court of Appeals* v. *Feldman*, 460 U. S. 462 (1983), the Court held that a Federal District Court lacked jurisdiction to "review" a final judicial determination of the D. C. high court because such "[r]eview . . . can be obtained only in this Court" under § 1257. *Id.*, at 476, 482. The plaintiffs there had challenged as unconstitutional a court rule requiring D. C. bar applicants to have graduated from an approved law school. They had also sought a waiver of that rule. This Court held that the Federal District Court had no jurisdiction to review the D. C. high court's denial of the plaintiffs' waiver petitions, but possessed jurisdiction to adjudicate the validity of the rule itself because, in the latter situation, the "district court is not reviewing a state-court judicial decision." *Id.*, at 486.

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Rooker and *Feldman* are thus built on two closely related bases of reasoning. The first is that, when plaintiffs "essentially invit[e] federal courts of first instance to review and reverse unfavorable state-court judgments," they are seeking an exercise of appellate jurisdiction. See *Exxon*, 544 U. S., at 283–284 (describing *Rooker* and *Feldman*). The second is that such "appellate jurisdiction to reverse or modify a state-court judgment is lodged, . . . by 28 U. S. C. § 1257,

exclusively in this Court." 544 U. S., at 283. Federal district courts, by contrast, are "empowered to exercise [only] original, not appellate, jurisdiction." *Ibid.*

In the years since *Rooker* and *Feldman*, this Court has refused to expand the *Rooker-Feldman* doctrine.[4] In the "narrow ground occupied by *Rooker-Feldman*," however, the Court has repeatedly reaffirmed its rule. *Exxon*, 544 U. S., at 284. In *Exxon*, the Court held that the "*Rooker-Feldman* doctrine . . . is confined to cases of the kind from which the doctrine acquired its name: cases brought by state-court losers complaining of injuries caused by state-court judgments rendered before the district court proceedings commenced and inviting district court review and rejection of those judgments." 544 U. S., at 284.[5] In those cases, *Rooker-Feldman* continues to require "dismiss[al] for want

[4] For instance, this Court has held that *Rooker-Feldman* does not apply when the federal plaintiff "was not a party in the state court" because that plaintiff would not have been in any "position to ask this Court to review the state court's judgment." *Johnson* v. *De Grandy*, 512 U. S. 997, 1006 (1994); see *Lance* v. *Dennis*, 546 U. S. 459, 466 (2006) (*per curiam*) (The "*Rooker-Feldman* doctrine does not bar actions by nonparties to the earlier state-court judgment" even if "they could be considered in privity with a party to the judgment"). This Court has also held that *Rooker-Feldman* does not apply when there is parallel litigation, such as when a party files a federal action raising the same claim as one in a state court action that has not yet reached a judgment. *Exxon*, 544 U. S., at 293–294. Finally, this Court has held that *Rooker-Feldman* bars suits "challeng[ing]" an "adverse" state-court decision, but does not bar a suit challenging a "statute or rule governing th[at state-court] decision." *Skinner* v. *Switzer*, 562 U. S. 521, 532 (2011); see also *Reed* v. *Goertz*, 598 U. S. 230, 235 (2023).

[5] *Exxon* elsewhere also noted that in both *Rooker* and *Feldman*, the federal plaintiffs sued "after the state proceedings ended." 544 U. S., at 291. The dissent argues that this fact was a "key featur[e]" of those cases, *post*, at 706–707 (opinion of BARRETT, J.), but *Exxon* never mentioned this fact in the cited "hold[ing]" when it described the "kind" of cases to which *Rooker-Feldman* still applies. See 544 U. S., at 284. Needless to say, neither *Rooker* nor *Feldman* constrained their rules of decision to cases that perfectly match their facts.

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of subject-matter jurisdiction." 544 U. S., at 284; see also *Lance* v. *Dennis*, 546 U. S. 459, 466 (2006) (*per curiam*) ("The doctrine applies only in 'limited circumstances' . . . where a party in effect seeks to take an appeal of an unfavorable state-court decision to a lower federal court"); *Reed* v. *Goertz*, 598 U. S. 230, 235 (2023) ("Th[e] doctrine prohibits federal courts from adjudicating cases brought by state-court losing parties challenging state-court judgments").

B

Under these precedents, T. M.'s case falls within "the narrow ground occupied by *Rooker-Feldman*." *Exxon*, 544 U. S., at 284. T. M. is complaining of injuries caused by, and is seeking relief from, the state-court judgment itself, arguing that the consent order violates her federal and state due process rights and was entered into under duress. See App. 40–45 (complaint alleging injuries stemming from the consent order). The consent order was rendered 10 days before T. M. commenced this federal lawsuit. T. M. plainly seeks "review and rejection" of the consent order by asking the District Court to "[d]eclare that the 'Consent Order'" is "unconstitutional, unenforceable, and void *ab initio*" and to enjoin "enforcement of the 'Consent Order.'" 139 F. 4th, at 347. Thus, T. M.'s case is the "'paradigm situation in which *Rooker-Feldman* precludes a federal district court from proceeding'": She does not like the result reached in state court and "repaired to federal court to undo the [state] judgment in [her] favor." *Exxon*, 544 U. S., at 293.

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III

Instead of disputing any of the points discussed above,[6] T. M. asks this Court to add a new requirement to the

[6] In the Fourth Circuit, T. M. contended that she was not a "'state-court loser'" and that her suit was "really about injuries inflicted by the medical center rather than the consent order," but the Fourth Circuit rejected those arguments and she has not raised them here. 139 F. 4th, at 350–352.

Rooker-Feldman doctrine. In T. M.'s view, endorsed by the dissent, the Court should adopt a new rule specifying that *Rooker-Feldman* bars only federal suits seeking review and rejection of "[f]inal judgments" that are "rendered by the highest court of a State in which a decision could be had," 28 U. S. C. § 1257(a). See Brief for Petitioner 19; *post*, at 706 (opinion of BARRETT, J.). Because that rule is inconsistent with the Court's precedents, risks producing anomalous results, and undermines federalism interests, the Court declines to adopt it.

A

T. M.'s theory, echoed by the dissent, fails because it requires a reimagining, rather than an application, of the Court's *Rooker-Feldman* precedents. Taking T. M.'s argument step-by-step illustrates the point.

In T. M.'s view, *Rooker-Feldman* has never rested on any distinction between what, in substance, qualifies as original and appellate jurisdiction. Instead, on her theory, an action commenced in federal district court "seeking the adjudication of a freestanding [federal-question] cause of action" always technically "invok[es] the district court's original jurisdiction" under 28 U. S. C. § 1331 and is akin to a collateral attack. Brief for Petitioner 32; see *post*, at 702–704 (opinion of BARRETT, J.). Therefore, as T. M. sees things, the Court's prior *Rooker-Feldman* cases should not be read to evince any concern about district courts exercising what amounts to appellate jurisdiction over state-court judgments, but instead should be read as relying on a strict negative inference, from § 1257, that when this Court has jurisdiction over a state-court judgment, district courts must not. In T. M.'s view, it follows from here that, for *Rooker-Feldman* to bar a federal suit, it is not enough that a state-court loser seeks what is effectively appellate review of a prior state-court judgment. For T. M., the judgment under attack must be a "[f]inal judgmen[t] or decre[e] rendered by the highest court of a State in which a decision could be had," § 1257(a), at the

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time the federal suit is initiated, because only then does this Court gain jurisdiction over a state-court judgment.

T. M.'s theory cannot be squared with this Court's precedents, which plainly adopted a different, more functional view of original and appellate jurisdiction than what T. M. advances here. In *Rooker*, for example, it was true that the judgment at issue had been affirmed by the state high court by the time the federal suit was filed, but nothing in this Court's reasoning suggested that the outcome would have been different had the judgment still been on appeal. There (as here), Rooker's federal suit sought to "reverse or modify the [state-court] judgment," which the Court held would be an "exercise of appellate jurisdiction," 263 U. S., at 416, and not a collateral attack invoking original jurisdiction. There (as here), the District Court would lack such "appellate" jurisdiction because it has "strictly original" jurisdiction. *Ibid.* There (as here), it would be the "province and duty of the state courts to decide" the federal questions first, and "[i]f the decision was wrong," Rooker could seek "reversal or modification in an appropriate and timely appellate proceeding," including in this Court under § 1257. *Id.*, at 415.

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Later cases delineating the bounds of *Rooker-Feldman*, see n. 4, *supra*, confirmed the understanding that *Rooker-Feldman* bars suits in federal district court that "see[k] what in substance would be appellate review of [a] state judgment," regardless of whether the judgment formally falls within this Court's § 1257 jurisdiction. *Johnson* v. *De Grandy*, 512 U. S. 997, 1005–1006 (1994). As this Court explained in *Exxon*, the doctrine "'recognizes that 28 U. S. C. § 1331 is a grant of original jurisdiction, and does not authorize district courts to exercise appellate jurisdiction over state-court judgments, which Congress has reserved to this Court, see § 1257(a).'" 544 U. S., at 292 (quoting *Verizon Md. Inc.* v. *Public Serv. Comm'n of Md.*, 535 U. S. 635, 644, n. 3 (2002)). In *Lance*, too, this Court emphasized that "[t]he doctrine applies only in 'limited circumstances' where a

party in effect seeks to take an appeal of an unfavorable state-court decision to a lower federal court." 546 U. S., at 466 (citation omitted). None of these cases suggests that district courts have jurisdiction to review state-court judgments, and declare them void, so long as the judgments are not yet within this Court's § 1257 jurisdiction.

In fact, *Feldman* explicitly rejected that notion. There, the Court addressed a Fifth Circuit case holding that *Rooker* did not apply because the judgment "'could not have been reviewed on a writ of certiorari from the United States Supreme Court,'" given the plaintiff's failure to raise the relevant federal issue in state court. 460 U. S., at 483, n. 16 (quoting *Dasher* v. *Supreme Ct. of Tex.*, 658 F. 2d 1045, 1051 (1981)). The Court rejected that reasoning as "flawed" because "the fact that we may not have jurisdiction to review a final state-court judgment . . . does not mean that a United States district court should have jurisdiction over the claims." 460 U. S., at 484, n. 16. After all, the Court explained, "'lower federal courts possess no power whatever to sit in direct review of state court decisions.'" *Id.*, at 483, n. 16; but see *id.*, at 490 (Stevens, J., dissenting) (arguing, as T. M. and the dissent do here, that the *Feldman* majority improperly "fail[ed] to distinguish between . . . appellate review and collateral attack"). *Feldman* thus explicitly rejected T. M.'s view that *Rooker* rested solely on a strict negative inference from § 1257.[7]

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[7] Indeed, even though the state-court judgment in *Rooker* v. *Fidelity Trust Co.*, 263 U. S. 413 (1923), was a final judgment of a state high court, it did not fall within this Court's certiorari jurisdiction under § 1257 either because the Court's jurisdictional deadline for filing the petition for a writ of certiorari had passed. See *id.*, at 416; this Court's Rule 13.2 (describing civil filing deadline as jurisdictional). Still, the Court reasoned, "an aggrieved litigant cannot be permitted to do indirectly" in federal district court "what he no longer can do directly" in this Court. 263 U. S., at 416. True, T. M. seeks federal appellate review of a state-court judgment prematurely (before receiving a final judgment this Court can review), whereas Rooker tried to do so belatedly. Either way, the same principle

The dissent, for its part, admits that this Court has relied on both §§ 1331 and 1257 in justifying *Rooker-Feldman*, but contends that *Exxon* "buried" and "discarded" the § 1331 rationale. *Post*, at 707–708. Had the Court in *Exxon* intended to bury or discard the § 1331 rationale, one might have expected it to say so rather than to quote affirmatively a case that directly describes the doctrine as resting on both §§ 1331 and 1257. See 544 U. S., at 292 (citing *Verizon Md. Inc.*, 535 U. S., at 644, n. 3). Moreover, *Exxon* acknowledged, without disapproval, *Rooker*'s reasoning that "[f]ederal district courts . . . lacked the requisite appellate authority, for their jurisdiction was 'strictly original.'" 544 U. S., at 284. It also summarized *Rooker* and *Feldman* as "essentially invit[ing] federal courts of first instance to review and reverse unfavorable state-court judgments," 544 U. S., at 283, and it held that Exxon's federal suit did not fall within *Rooker-Feldman* because Exxon did "not repai[r] to federal court to undo the Delaware judgment in its favor," 544 U. S., at 293. All these statements are only consistent with the view that *Rooker-Feldman* is based on both §§ 1331 and 1257, and none even suggests that the state-court judgment at issue must be a "[f]inal judgmen[t] . . . rendered by the highest court of a State" under § 1257(a).[8]

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applies: T. M. "cannot be permitted to do indirectly" what she cannot yet "do directly." *Ibid.*

[8] The dissent also appears to equate *Exxon*'s reference to the fact that "'state proceedings [had] ended'" in *Rooker* and *Feldman* with a judgment being final under § 1257. *Post*, at 706 (emphasis deleted). *Exxon*, however, did not itself draw that connection. Likely as a result, many of the Circuits that interpreted *Exxon* to hold that *Rooker-Feldman* applies only when state-court proceedings have "ended" have not adopted T. M. and the dissent's § 1257 finality rule. See, *e.g.*, *Federación de Maestros de P. R.* v. *Junta de Relaciones del Trabajo de P. R.*, 410 F. 3d 17, 24–25 (CA1 2005); *Malhan*, 938 F. 3d, at 459–460 (collecting cases). They instead reasoned that a state proceeding may "end" even without a final judgment from a state high court, such as when a state-court loser does not appeal to the state high court. See *Federación de Maestros*, 410 F. 3d, at 24–25. Based on this reasoning, these Circuits created multipart analyses to

Ultimately, adopting T. M. and the dissent's rule would require the Court to abandon a central part of *Rooker*'s reasoning and reinterpret the doctrine to rest solely on a strict negative inference from § 1257. See Brief for Petitioner 33–34 (acknowledging that the Court's precedents have rested in part based on the distinction between original and appellate jurisdiction); *post*, at 704 (acknowledging that *Rooker* rested in part on § 1331). The Court declines to do so.

B

The fact that T. M. and the dissent's rule departs from this Court's precedents is enough to affirm the dismissal of T. M.'s suit under *Rooker-Feldman*. If more is necessary, however, the Court also declines to distort the *Rooker-Feldman* doctrine in service of a rule that would create anomalous outcomes and undermine the federalism principles upon which the doctrine rests. The upshot of T. M. and the dissent's rule would be that federal district courts could not exercise jurisdiction if a plaintiff seeks review of a state high-court judgment, but they could exercise jurisdiction if the plaintiff seeks the same review of a state lower-court judgment while that judgment is on appeal in the state-court system. That makes little sense.

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To start, allowing federal district courts to review state-court judgments while they are on appeal in the state-court system would undermine the "[c]ooperation and comity" on which our federal system is built. *Ruhrgas AG* v. *Marathon Oil Co.*, 526 U. S. 574, 586 (1999). Indeed, that is the reason why, "ever since 1789, Congress has granted this Court the power to intervene in State litigation only after 'the highest court of a State in which a decision in the suit could be had' has rendered a 'final judgment.'" *Radio Station WOW, Inc.* v. *Johnson*, 326 U. S. 120, 124 (1945); see *North Dakota Bd.*

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determine whether state proceedings have functionally "ended" (and thus *Rooker-Feldman* may apply), see 410 F. 3d, at 24–25, which neither the dissent nor T. M. embrace.

of Pharmacy v. *Snyder's Drug Stores, Inc.*, 414 U. S. 156, 159 (1973) (explaining that one of §1257's purposes is to "limi[t] review of state court determinations of federal constitutional issues to leave at a minimum federal intrusion in state affairs"). It is difficult to see why Congress would have authorized district courts to review final state-court judgments pending appeal in state court when it did not authorize this Court to do so.

T. M. and the dissent's rule also would produce arbitrarily different results depending on when, exactly, a federal suit seeking review of a state-court judgment is filed. In their view, a district court can review a state-court judgment so long as it has not been affirmed by the state high court by the time the federal action is filed. Yet a state high court may well affirm such a judgment while such a federal action is still pending. In that event, the plaintiff would be in the exact same situation *Rooker* disapproved: seeking to have declared null and void "a judgment of a [state court], which was affirmed by the Supreme Court of the State." 263 U. S., at 414. Yet, under T. M. and the dissent's rule, a district court would have jurisdiction to proceed simply because the plaintiff filed her federal suit while the state appellate proceedings were pending, rather than waiting for the state high court to act. Such a rule would only encourage parties to file earlier in federal court, duplicating their efforts even though the state process may well resolve the dispute in their favor.

T. M., her *amici*, and the dissent respond that federal courts have at their disposal various abstention and preclusion doctrines, which generally prevent federal courts from interfering with state proceedings or bar parties from relitigating issues already decided. According to T. M., those doctrines prevent federal-court intervention while state appellate proceedings are ongoing and thus do "nearly all," but apparently not all, "of the work that *Rooker-Feldman* does." Reply Brief 18; see Brief for Federal Courts Scholars as

Amici Curiae 7–16 (listing nine doctrines); see also *post*, at 705–706 (opinion of BARRETT, J.) (describing preclusion and abstention doctrines). It is unclear, however, if such doctrines even apply in cases, like this one, where a plaintiff does not attempt to relitigate the same claims in state and federal forums but rather complains of injuries that stem directly from a state-court judgment. See Letter Order in No. 1:23–cv–1684 (D Md.), ECF Doc. 27, pp. 3–5 (holding that neither abstention under *Younger* v. *Harris*, 401 U. S. 37 (1971), nor *Colorado River Water Conservation Dist.* v. *United States*, 424 U. S. 800 (1976), nor Maryland's collateral-attack doctrine applied to this case); see also *Lucky Brand Dungarees, Inc.* v. *Marcel Fashions Group, Inc.*, 590 U. S. 405, 411 (2020) (explaining that issue preclusion "precludes a party from relitigating an issue actually decided in a prior case and necessary to the judgment"). Federalism principles are thus best served by continuing to apply *Rooker-Feldman* to federal cases in which plaintiffs seek review of state-court judgments, regardless of whether those judgments are final trial-court judgments or those of a State's highest court.[9]

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C

Finally, T. M. contends that the Court should adopt her position for the more practical reason that it will generally cabin *Rooker-Feldman*, a doctrine she claims has caused con-

[9] Strangely, the dissent resists the idea that federalism principles play any role in *Rooker-Feldman* at all. *Post*, at 709–712. It is true that neither *Rooker* nor *Feldman* uses the word "federalism," but both discuss the appropriate roles of the state and federal courts. See *supra*, at 676–678. The dissent's resistance to acknowledging federalism values here is also inconsistent with its own interpretation of *Rooker-Feldman* as a "'§ 1257 Rule.'" *Post*, at 712. The Court has consistently explained that § 1257's finality requirement rests in part on principles of federalism. See *Pennsylvania* v. *Ritchie*, 480 U. S. 39, 48–49, n. 7 (1987) ("[T]he justifications for the finality doctrine" include "efficiency, judicial restraint, and federalism"); *Radio Station WOW, Inc.* v. *Johnson*, 326 U. S. 120, 124 (1945) (similar).

fusion and is overused as a docket-clearing mechanism in the lower courts. See Brief for Petitioner 35. As T. M. admits, however, most of the confusion in the lower courts "stems from the need to determine when a plaintiff is seeking federal 'review and rejection' of a state-court judgment." *Id.*, at 37; see *Gilbank* v. *Wood Cty. Dept. of Human Servs.*, 111 F. 4th 754, 792–798 (CA7 2024) (en banc) (majority opinion of Kirsch, J.); *id.*, at 760, 769–778 (dissenting opinion of Hamilton, J.) (describing the confusion over the "'review and rejection'" requirement). That "review and rejection" question is not disputed in this case, so adopting T. M.'s rule does nothing to ameliorate any confusion over that distinct issue.[10]

In fact, T. M.'s and the dissent's rule would needlessly complicate the *Rooker-Feldman* analysis. It is not always straightforward to determine whether a given state-court judgment is a reviewable final judgment under § 1257(a) because that question requires determining whether the judgment is both "subject to no further review or correction in any other state tribunal" and also "an effective determination of the litigation." *Market Street R. Co.* v. *Railroad Comm'n of Cal.*, 324 U. S. 548, 551 (1945). Nor is it necessarily clear when state proceedings have "ended." See *Fed-*

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[10] Nor did the Fourth Circuit apply an overly broad interpretation of "review and rejection" in this case. It emphasized that T. M.'s complaint, which plainly sought to void and enjoin the consent order, sat "[i]n contrast" to two other federal actions T. M. filed, neither of which were dismissed under *Rooker-Feldman*. 139 F. 4th, at 352, n. 2. The first was a due-process suit, which she voluntarily dismissed but which *Rooker-Feldman* would not have barred because it was commenced before the consent order was entered. 139 F. 4th, at 352, n. 2.; see *Exxon*, 544 U. S., at 293–294. The second was a federal discrimination suit, which was dismissed on the merits and did not implicate *Rooker-Feldman* because, though it involved the same parties and facts, the suit did not seek review and rejection of the consent order. 139 F. 4th, at 352, n. 2.; see *Doe* v. *University of Md. Medical System Corp.*, 2025 WL 3553026, *1–*2 (CA4, Dec. 11, 2025) (describing T. M.'s claims).

eración de Maestros de P. R., 410 F. 3d, at 24–25 (describing test to determine whether proceedings have functionally "ended"). For example, in this case, the parties dispute whether the consent order is appealable under Maryland law. See Brief in Opposition 23–24; Reply to Brief in Opposition 9–10. If it is not, then the consent order may be final for § 1257 purposes and the "end" of state-court proceedings. Further, even if a state judgment is technically subject to further review in state proceedings, it may nevertheless be reviewable by this Court under § 1257 under a limited set of circumstances. See *Cox Broadcasting Corp.* v. *Cohn*, 420 U. S. 469, 477–486 (1975) (describing four sets of circumstances within the Court's "pragmatic approach" to finality). Thus, T. M. and the dissent's rule would both fail to address the source of confusion in the current *Rooker-Feldman* doctrine and add a new source to the mix.

Finally, the animating force behind many of T. M.'s and the dissent's arguments appears to be the belief that *Rooker* and *Feldman* were wrongly decided and so should be cabined whenever possible, if not outright overruled. Cf. *post*, at 702–706 (raising doubts about *Rooker-Feldman*'s conceptual basis). This issue is not fairly included in the question presented and was not pressed at the certiorari stage. See this Court's Rule 14.1(a).

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IV

The Court today neither expands nor constrains *Rooker-Feldman*. Instead, the Court leaves the doctrine as it found it: narrowly confined to "cases brought by state-court losers complaining of injuries caused by state-court judgments rendered before the district court proceedings commenced and inviting district court review and rejection of those judgments." *Exxon*, 544 U. S., at 284. Because T. M.'s suit falls within these strict limits, the judgment of the Court of Appeals for the Fourth Circuit is affirmed.

It is so ordered.

JUSTICE THOMAS, concurring.

When you lose in trial court, you go to an appeals court. The so-called *Rooker-Feldman* doctrine reflects that commonsense understanding. See *Rooker* v. *Fidelity Trust Co.*, 263 U. S. 413 (1923); *District of Columbia Court of Appeals* v. *Feldman*, 460 U. S. 462 (1983). At its core, the doctrine says that parties who lose in state trial court do not get to appeal to a federal trial court. Instead, they may take their appeal to a state appeals court and, if a federal statute allows, ultimately seek review in this Court. That "basic fact" has been a part of our law for more than 200 years. *Reed* v. *Goertz*, 598 U. S. 230, 244 (2023) (THOMAS, J., dissenting). The Court's opinion thus properly rejects petitioner's quest to reimagine, artificially cabin, or overrule *Rooker-Feldman*. *Ante*, at 676–688. I join it in full. I write separately to explain why *Rooker*, properly understood, is correct as an original matter.

I

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A unanimous three-page opinion, *Rooker* was uncontroversial in its day. It started as an ordinary lawsuit. William and Dora Rooker sued Fidelity Trust Company in state court. See *Rooker* v. *Fidelity Trust Co.*, 191 Ind. 141, 143, 131 N. E. 769, 770 (1921). The trial court entered judgment against the Rookers. *Id.*, at 154–155, 131 N. E., at 773. The Rookers sought review in the State Supreme Court and lost. *Id.*, at 163, 131 N. E., at 776. This Court denied certiorari. *Rooker* v. *Fidelity Trust Co.*, 259 U. S. 580 (1922). The Rookers then sought review from this Court on a writ of error instead. *Rooker* v. *Fidelity Trust Co.*, 261 U. S. 114, 116 (1923). But, the Court declined to grant relief on their claims of constitutional errors in the state-court judgment and dismissed the writ. *Id.*, at 116–118.

Unsatisfied, the Rookers filed a bill in equity in Federal District Court. *Rooker*, 263 U. S., at 414. They asked the Federal District Court to declare the state trial court's judg-